

What is Waqf?

Waqf means stopping or pausing during recitation. Knowing WHERE to stop is critical — a wrong pause can completely change the meaning of a verse.

5 Waqf Signs in the Mushaf

Sign	Name	Meaning	What to Do
meem (small m)	Waqf Laazim (Compulsory)	Must stop here — continuing changes meaning	ALWAYS stop here, no exceptions
Taa (small T)	Waqf Mutlaq (Permitted/Good)	Good place to stop — meaning is complete	Should stop here if needed
Jeem (small j)	Waqf Jaa'iz (Permissible)	Both stopping and continuing are acceptable	Optional — your choice
Zaa (small z)	Al-Wasl Awla (Better to continue)	Prefer to continue, stopping is allowed	Try to continue if breath allows
laa (no stop)	Waqf Mamnoo' (Forbidden)	DO NOT stop here — meaning will be distorted	NEVER stop — continue always

How to Stop on a Word

RULE: When you stop on any word, REMOVE the final vowel — the last letter gets Sukoon.

Type of Ending	Rule	Example
Normal ending (damma, fatha, kasra)	Remove vowel → silent ending	Rabbul → Rabb (silent ba)
Tanween Fatha (an sound)	Becomes long Alif sound	Ahadan → Ahada (long aa)
Tanween Damma or Kasra	Remove the tanween, just silent ending	Kitaabun → Kitaab
Ending in Ta Marbuta (ah)	Ta becomes silent Ha	Rahmatan → Rahmah

Where to Start After Stopping

If you stopped in an incorrect place, you must go BACK to a safe starting point:

- Best: start from the beginning of a sentence or after a period (full stop in meaning)
- Good: start from the beginning of a clause
- Acceptable: start from the word just before where you stopped
- Never: start from the middle of a connected phrase that cannot stand alone

Al-Fatiha — Natural Stop Points

- After 'Bismillaahir Rahmaanir Raheem' — natural pause

- After 'Alhamdu Lillaahi Rabbil Aalameen'
- After 'Ar-Rahmaanir Raheem'
- After 'Maaliki Yawmid-Deen'
- After 'Iyyaaka Na'budu Wa Iyyaaka Nasta'een'
- After 'Ihdinas-Siraatal Mustaqeem'
- At the end: 'Wa lad-Daaaalleen' — natural full stop

★ **The most important rule: if in doubt, continue. Stopping at a good place is better than stopping at a harmful place.**